TEXORA · COURSE NOTES · LECTURE SHEET

Introduction to Sociology

What sociology is, what kind of science it is, what it studies, why it matters — and how social interaction, its basic unit, works.

HUM-2209 · SOCIOLOGY AND HUMAN ECOLOGY · TOPIC 1 · LEVEL 2 TERM 2

1. What sociology is

The word **sociology** is built from the Latin *socius* (companion, associate) and the Greek *logos* (study or science). Literally, it is the science of society. The French thinker **Auguste Comte** coined the term in 1839 and is honoured as the **father of sociology**; he wanted a positive science that would study society with the same care with which physics studies nature.

Later thinkers sharpened the definition in different directions, and the differences matter because each one tells you what that thinker believed society really is:

- **Auguste Comte** — sociology is the science of social phenomena, studying society as a whole, subject to natural laws of progress.
- **Émile Durkheim** — sociology is the science of *social facts*: ways of acting, thinking and feeling that exist outside the individual and exercise control over him (laws, customs, moral rules).
- **Max Weber** — sociology is the interpretive understanding of *social action*: behaviour to which the actor attaches meaning and which takes account of others.
- **Morris Ginsberg** — sociology is the study of human interactions and interrelations, their conditions and their consequences.
- **Harry M. Johnson** — sociology is the science that deals with social groups: their internal forms, the processes that maintain or change them, and their relations to one another.

A working definition for this course: **sociology is the systematic study of society, social relationships, social institutions and social behaviour.** It asks not only what people do, but why groups hold together, why they change, and how an individual's life is shaped by the groups and the age into which he or she is born.

2. The nature of sociology

Examiners love this list. Sociology is:

- **A social science, not a natural science** — its subject matter is human society, not the physical world.
- **A categorical, not a normative, science** — it studies what *is*, not what *ought to be*. The sociologist describes and explains; he does not preach.
- **A pure science, not an applied one** — its first aim is knowledge about society, though that knowledge is constantly used by planners, administrators and social workers.
- **An abstract, not a concrete, science** — it studies the forms and patterns of relationships (authority, cooperation, conflict), not any one particular village or factory.
- **A generalising science** — it looks for general principles across cases rather than cataloguing single events.
- **An empirical and rational science** — its claims rest on observation, data and reasoning, not on revelation or pure speculation.

3. The scope of sociology

How wide should the subject be? Two classic schools answer differently:

SCHOOL	MAIN THINKERS	POSITION
Formalistic (specialistic) school	Georg Simmel, Max Weber, Ferdinand Tönnies, Alfred Vierkandt	Sociology should have a narrow, definite field: the *forms* of social relationships (competition, cooperation, domination) abstracted from their contents, just as geometry studies forms of objects.
Synthetic school	Émile Durkheim, L. T. Hobhouse, Pitirim Sorokin	Sociology should study society *as a whole*, synthesising the findings of the special social sciences (economics, political science, history) into one picture of social life.

In practice the modern subject covers both. Its main areas of study include: social structure and institutions (family, marriage, kinship), religion, education, economy and industry, polity and law, social stratification, population, rural and urban society, social change, and social problems such as crime, poverty and unemployment. This course touches most of them: culture, stratification, industry, population and community all appear in later topics.

4. Importance and uses of sociology

- **Understanding one's own society.** Sociology replaces rumour and prejudice with tested knowledge about how our institutions actually work.

- **Understanding other societies.** It studies cultures unlike our own, which builds tolerance and makes cooperation across groups possible.
- **Solving social problems.** Crime, addiction, unemployment and communal tension cannot be treated intelligently until their social causes are known.
- **Planning and policy.** Development plans, population policy and labour law all draw on sociological research — this is why sociology is taught to engineers, doctors and administrators, not only to arts students.
- **Professional life.** Industry runs on groups: shifts, teams, unions, management. An engineer who understands authority, morale and informal groups manages people better than one who sees only machines.
- **Adjusting to change.** Societies now change within a single lifetime; sociology explains the forces driving the change and helps individuals and institutions adapt instead of merely suffering it.

5. Sociology and the other social sciences

SCIENCE	WHAT IT STUDIES	RELATION TO SOCIOLOGY
History	Past events — particular societies, persons and dates	History is idiographic (describes particulars); sociology is nomothetic (seeks general laws). Yet each feeds the other: sociology needs historical data, history needs sociological concepts.
Economics	Production, exchange and consumption of goods and services	Economic behaviour is always social behaviour. Unemployment, wages and markets cannot be fully explained without class, custom and institutions; classical economists were often sociologists too.
Political science	The state, government and power	Power operates inside every group, not only in the state. Sociology studies the social roots of authority; political sociology is the shared ground.
Psychology	The individual mind and behaviour	Psychology starts from the individual, sociology from the group; social psychology bridges them — personality itself is formed in interaction.
Anthropology	Humankind — originally simple and pre-literate societies, and physical/cultural evolution	The closest relative. Anthropology traditionally studied small, simple societies as wholes; sociology the complex modern ones. Methods (fieldwork) and concepts (culture) are largely shared.

Geography	The physical environment and its distribution over space	Environment conditions social life (settlement, occupation, density). Human ecology — Topic 5 of this course — is where the two meet.

6. Social interaction: the basic process

Society is not a thing but a web of interactions. **Social interaction** is the process by which two or more persons, in contact, mutually influence each other's behaviour. It needs two elements: **social contact** (coming into one another's presence, directly or through media) and **communication** (the exchange of meanings through language and symbols). Without communication, contact stays physical and no interaction occurs.

The main forms of interaction are:

- **Cooperation** — working together for a shared goal: a production team meeting a target, villagers raising a harvest. The most basic and necessary form; society cannot exist without it.
- **Competition** — striving against others for a scarce goal while following shared rules: candidates in an examination, firms in a market. Impersonal and rule-bound, it motivates effort and allocates positions.
- **Conflict** — open struggle in which each side tries to defeat or harm the other: strikes turning violent, communal clashes, war. Unlike competition, it breaks the rules and seeks the rival's removal; yet in measured doses it can also clear blocked grievances and redraw unfair arrangements.
- **Accommodation** — the adjustment by which hostile or unequal parties learn to work together: compromise, tolerance, arbitration, the formal agreement between management and union.
- **Assimilation** — the deeper, slower process in which distinct groups gradually take on one another's culture until they become alike in outlook: migrants adopting the ways of the city over a generation.
- **Exchange** — interaction as give-and-take of goods, services, approval and status, on which much of economic and social life runs.

Interaction is the raw material of everything that follows in this course: culture is learned and passed on through it, stratification is produced and challenged through it, and community development (Topic 7) is nothing but organised interaction aimed at improvement.

7. Glossary — key terms of this topic

TERM	MEANING
Social fact	Durkheim's term for ways of acting, thinking and feeling external to the individual that exercise constraint over him — laws, customs, moral codes.

Social action	Weber's term for behaviour that is meaningful to the actor and oriented to the behaviour of others.
Society	A web of social relationships among people who share a territory, a culture and a sense of belonging together.
Institution	An established, organised pattern for meeting a basic social need — family, education, religion, economy, polity.
Social interaction	Mutual influence between two or more persons through contact and communication.
Accommodation	The adjustment of hostile or competing parties so that they can work together without open conflict.
Assimilation	The process by which distinct cultural groups gradually become alike in attitudes and ways of life.

8. Key points and summary

- Sociology, the term coined by Comte (1839), is the systematic science of society and social relationships; Durkheim centred it on social facts, Weber on meaningful social action.
- It is a social, categorical, pure, abstract, generalising and empirical science — describing what is, not prescribing what ought to be.
- Its scope is debated between the formalistic school (study the forms of relationships) and the synthetic school (study society whole); modern sociology does both.
- It is closely related to history, economics, political science, psychology, anthropology and geography, borrowing from and lending to each.
- Social interaction — contact plus communication — takes the forms of cooperation, competition, conflict, accommodation, assimilation and exchange, and underlies every other topic of this course.

9. Practice

Answer in your own words; brief model answers follow.

1. Define sociology. Why is Comte called its father?
2. “Sociology is a categorical, not a normative, science.” Explain with one example.
3. Distinguish the formalistic and synthetic schools on the scope of sociology. Which view does the structure of this course follow? Give a reason.

4. Sociology and economics study many of the same facts about a factory. State two questions each would ask about it.
5. A strike begins in a garment factory, the parties negotiate, an agreement is signed, and over years the workers' union and management develop shared customs. Identify the forms of interaction in this sequence.
6. Why can there be contact without interaction? Give an example.

Answer key

1. Sociology is the systematic study of society, social relationships, institutions and behaviour. Comte coined the term (1839) and first designed it as a positive science of society.
2. Categorical means it states what is the case, not what ought to be. Example: sociology can measure how common dowry is and explain its causes; whether dowry should be abolished is a moral/legal judgement, not a sociological finding.
3. Formalistic: sociology studies only the forms of relationships (Simmel, Weber). Synthetic: it studies society as a whole and synthesises the special sciences (Durkheim, Hobhouse). This course follows the synthetic view — it ranges over culture, industry, population and economics as parts of one society.
4. Economics: What wage minimises cost per dozen? How does output respond to a price change? Sociology: How do shift groups and supervisors build authority and morale? How does the workers' migration background shape union membership?
5. Strike — conflict; negotiation — accommodation beginning; signed agreement — accommodation completed (compromise); shared customs — movement towards assimilation of practices.
6. Interaction requires communication — the exchange of meanings. Two strangers pressed together in a bus are in physical contact, but if no meaning passes between them, no social interaction has occurred.

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